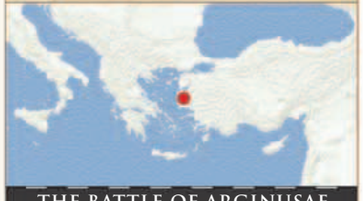


Triremes in the Aegean
Triremes could either move forward with their sails raised, sailing with the wind, or under oar power alone. Once two fleets had met and battle was joined, the sails – and often the masts as well – would be lowered.

to the slave and foreign oarsmen. But the aftermath of the battle was less than satisfactory. Most of the Athenian force was to sail to Mytilene to destroy the Spartan blockading force, while the rest would rescue crews clinging to the 25 wrecked Athenian triremes. But a sudden storm prevented either of these plans being put into effect. The failure to save the shipwrecked crews caused such outrage in Athens that six of the victorious generals were executed.

THE PELOPONNESIAN WAR



THE BATTLE OF ARGINUSAE

Date	406 BCE
Location	East of the island of Lesbos
Result	Athenian victory

COMBATANTS

ATHENS	SPARTA AND ALLIES

COMMANDERS

Eight generals	Callicratidas

FORCES

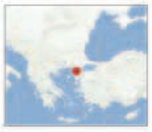
Ships: 143 triremes	**Ships:** 120 triremes

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** 25 triremes	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** 70 triremes

THE PELOPONNESIAN WAR

AEGOSPOTAMI



Date 404 BCE
Forces Spartans: unknown; Athenians: 170 ships
Losses Spartans: none; Athenians: 160 ships

Location
The Hellespont

The Hellespont was crucial to Athens, for grain convoys passed through it on their way from the Black Sea and without them Athens would starve. The Spartans were able to threaten this lifeline in 404 BCE because of an alliance with the Persians, which gave them the resources to revenge their losses at Arginusae. They recalled their most successful naval commander, Lysander, to lead the new fleet.

Lysander entered the Hellespont and captured the town of Lampsacus. The Athenian fleet, under the collective command of six generals, came after him and beached at Aegospotami opposite Lampsacus. It was a wild location that lacked adequate supplies for the thousands of sailors and marines, forcing the Athenians to bring the Spartans immediately to battle. On four consecutive days the Athenian fleet sortied toward Lampsacus, but each time Lysander refused to be drawn and remained in harbor.

What happened on the fifth day is a matter of dispute. According to the most likely version, Philocles, the Athenian general commanding that day, sent a small force of triremes toward Lampsacus to lure Lysander out. The Athenians were then to launch swiftly from their beach and crush the Spartans. But the plan misfired. The Spartan fleet swiftly smashed the triremes at sea and then destroyed the main force before it could get off the beach and into formation. Only 10 Athenian ships escaped. Lysander had Philocles and 3,000 other Athenian prisoners executed. With its fleet destroyed and no resources to build a new one, Athens surrendered the following year.

DIED 395 BCE

LYSANDER

SPARTAN GENERAL AND NAVAL COMMANDER

Having risen from poor origins, Lysander was appointed nauarch, or admiral-in-chief, of Sparta in 407 BCE. It was a post that could be held only for one year and never twice by the same individual. Lysander cultivated close relations with Cyrus, wealthy son of the Persian emperor Darius II, and thus obtained funds to strengthen the Spartan fleet, creating a naval force capable of challenging Athenian naval might. He defeated an Athenian fleet under Alcibiades at Notium, before his term of office came to an end. After the Spartan defeat at Arginusae Lysander was restored to command, although not accorded the official post of nauarch. His victory at Aegospotami allowed Lysander to make himself the most powerful man in Greece. He was an arrogant and cruel individual, but an inspired naval leader.

CREW PROFILE

GREEK TRIREME

5TH CENTURY BCE

A TRIREME REQUIRED A CREW of around 200 men. In Athens responsibility for recruiting them fell to a trierarch, a wealthy individual who had this task imposed upon him as one of his duties as a citizen. Since the trierarch was unlikely to have much seagoing experience, once at sea he was heavily dependent upon his four naval officers—the helmsman, rowing master, purser, and bow officer—who between them effectively ran the ship. The men on board most similar to the trierarch in social status were the ship's 10 hoplite soldiers.

THE OARSMEN

The oarsmen, who made up the majority of the crew, were usually free men hired from among the poorest citizens. Foreigners were employed when local oarsmen could not be found in sufficient numbers. Only experienced rowers skilled and hardened to the job were really useful, and they could command a good wage. Rowing maneuvers were practiced relentlessly once a crew was assembled. The oarsmen were seated in three rows, the thalamites at the bottom close to the waterline, the zygites in the middle, and the thranites in the highest row at the top. Thranites had the hardest job, because of the angle at which their oars struck the water. They tended to command higher wages than the others. As free men, the oarsmen were generally decently treated. Although they were occasionally expected to take part in fighting with hand weapons, they were normally considered too valuable to risk losing in close combat. Desertion was often a problem, as oarsmen would leave to join a ship offering higher pay, especially if their trierarch's money ran out, as sometimes happened.



Trireme oarsmen
By the time of the Peloponnesian War, Athens had increased her fleet to 200 triremes, each requiring 170 oarsmen seated in 3 tiers on each side.